

PSY 410 MORAL PSYCHOLOGY

Course Syllabus (CRN: [17009](#))



TR 12:00 – 1:20 PM

Lokey Education Building 117,
University of Oregon

COURSE DESCRIPTION

Moral psychology is the scientific study of how we determine right from wrong, act or fail to act on those standards, judge and punish others for their moral transgressions, and throughout, maintain that *we* personally are good, even when our actions suggest otherwise. In this course, we will talk about some of the greatest human acts and the most depraved. We will seek to understand those who see the world differently from us and deepen our understanding of ourselves. This course explores topics such as moral licensing and hypocrisy, egoism and altruism, empathy and its limits, blame and moral responsibility, the role of intuition versus reason in moral judgment, moral character evaluation, and moral understanding. There are many ways to approach the study of moral psychology. This course draws most heavily from insights from *social psychology* research, and therefore most topics covered pertain to morality within social contexts, e.g., thinking about, reacting to, influencing, and judging the (im)moral behavior and character of others. However, the course is interdisciplinary by nature, drawing from ideas and research from philosophy, behavioral economics, cognitive psychology, personality psychology, developmental psychology, neuroscience, biology, and other social science fields.

OFFICE HOURS



Instructor

Sarah Dimakis, Ph.D. ("Sarah")
sdimakis@uoregon.edu
WR 1:30 – 3:00 PM, or by
appointment
Straub 437



Graduate Teaching Fellow

Fiona DeBernardi, M.S.
fionadeb@uoregon.edu
TBD

CONTACTING US

Please don't hesitate to contact us if you have any questions or concerns. We are always happy to help. When you e-mail us, **please add PSY410 to the subject line** (e.g., "PSY410 exam question") so that we know which class you are from. I teach three classes per term, so this really helps me keep things organized and answer your question quickly. I recommend e-mailing Fiona for case study exam questions and Sarah for everything else. If you e-mail us, you can expect to receive a response within 2 business days, and typically earlier. If we do not respond to your email within 2 business days, please resend it (making sure PSY410 is in the title) because we may have not received it.

COURSE MATERIALS

There is no assigned textbook for this course. All readings will be posted on Canvas at the beginning of the course, including a mixture of empirical articles that conduct original research and review articles that synthesize the research of many scientists. Some review articles ("opinion" articles) offer conjecture from researchers that go beyond the facts of what they or others have observed. Occasionally the readings will be supplemented with short videos or podcast episodes. To maximize your understanding and participation in lectures and discussions, I strongly recommend completing the assigned readings **before the class they correspond to**. Learning to read psychology articles can be challenging, as they are often written for an audience familiar with the specialized terminology of the subfield who have advanced knowledge of journal article structure and

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

customs. It takes effort and practice to read them fluently, but the payoff is absolutely worth it. Note that the readings for this course vary in difficulty. Some are written for a general audience, while others are intended for peers in the field.

In this course, you will be developing important skills that are valuable outside of university, like introspection, critical thinking, writing, and speaking. You will also be working to improve skills that are necessary to be a consumer and/or producer of research, like reading, communicating about, and critically evaluating psychology research. Upon completion of this course, you will be able to (1) describe and identify important theories and research findings in moral psychology, (2) read novel research in moral psychology from academic journals, and (3) apply moral psychology theory and research findings to experiences in your life.

COURSE MODALITY

This is an in-person course with a lot of opportunities to discuss the material with other students and with the entire class. Discussion and active retrieval are necessary components of encoding information into long term memory, and the material in this course begs to be discussed. Every Tuesday, we will have an interactive lecture. Every Thursday, we will have a ~30-minute mini-lecture and then break out into smaller groups to discuss a set of discussion questions. Unlike asynchronous online/ASYNC WEB courses, we will meet during scheduled class meeting times in *Lokey 117*, which is located just off Alder St. near the Knight Library. I will accommodate absences as described in the Participation section below. I understand that a course that requires active participation and small group discussions is not for everyone, and I recommend a different elective course if you need additional flexibility. If you need accommodation related to a medical or other disability, you can request those by working with the Accessible Education Center.

ESTIMATED STUDENT WORKLOAD

When you complete this course, you will earn 4 credits toward your degree. A four-credit course from the University of Oregon is equivalent to 120 hours of work across the term, or 12 hours per week for 10 weeks. You will spend 30 hours in class, 40 hours on readings (for about 4 hours per week), and the remaining 50 hours completing take home assignments (reading quizzes, reflections, exams).

GRADING

Your learning will be assessed through take-home case study exams (40% of your grade), multiple-choice online reading and lecture quizzes (40% of your grade), reflections on important moral questions (15% of your grade), and self-reported participation in class discussions (5% of your grade).

Case Study Exams (x2)	40%
Reading Quizzes (x5, lowest dropped)	40%
Reflections (x4, lowest dropped)	15%
Course Participation	5%

The following grid provides the letter grade associated with each percent. If you are within .5% of a grade category (e.g., 89.5%), your grade will be rounded up if you have a 100% in the course participation category. A student may be assigned an "A+" for a final grade if they demonstrate exemplary understanding of the course material across all assessments (> 97% on all four grade categories).

A 93-100%	B 83-86.99%	C 73-76.99%	D 63-66.99%
A- 90-92.99%	B- 80-82.99%	C- 70-72.99%	D- 60-62.99%
B+ 87-89.99%	C+ 77-79.99%	D+ 67-69.99%	F 59.99% or below

TAKE-HOME EXAMS

There are two **take-home exams** for this course that will test your ability to apply moral psychology theories and findings to real world case studies. The exams are untimed, and you are encouraged to use notes, readings, and the internet to complete them. You are welcome to collaborate with other students in the class on **brainstorming ideas**, but the work you submit must be your own (i.e., your write up should not be identical to another student in the class). In 5 essays questions, you will research given case studies and apply what you are learning in class readings, lecture, and discussions to gain a deeper understanding of each case. For instance, I may ask you to research a specific case of fraud and ask you to apply course concepts to better understand why the fraud occurred. Take-home exams are due on Canvas **on Sunday, November 2nd (week 5) and Wednesday, December 10th (finals week) at 11:59pm.**

QUIZZES

To provide you with real-time feedback of how well you are understanding theories and findings from readings, lecture, and discussion, there will be five multiple-choice quizzes across the term. Each quiz contains 20 questions covering content since the last quiz. The quizzes are untimed, and you are encouraged to use your notes and readings to complete them, but the work you submit must be your own (i.e., no collaboration with other students or the internet, including AI). Your final quiz grade will drop the lowest score. Quizzes are due on Canvas on **Sundays at 11:59pm of even-numbered weeks.**

REFLECTIONS

Reflection assignments serve to deepen your personal connection and retention of the course material by having you reflect on various moral questions. Each assignment will have some activity (e.g., complete a questionnaire, watch a video) and then you will write a short, informal essay (max 1 page, double spaced) in response to a prompt. Your final reflection grade will drop the lowest score. Reflections are due on Canvas on **Sundays at 11:59pm of odd-numbered weeks** and graded excellent (A)/pass (B)/fail (F).

PARTICIPATION & ABSENCES

At the end of the course, you will grade your own participation based on the following criteria: **A (Excellent)** = I missed 3 or fewer classes. During group discussions, I contributed regularly and helped further and deepen the conversation. In full-class discussions, I spoke up as much as I felt comfortable and actively engaged with my peers' ideas. I was regularly prepared for class, attentive, and respectful of others' ideas. **B (Good)** = I missed somewhere between 3 and 6 classes. During group discussions, I sometimes contributed but was not the most consistent. In full-class discussions, I spoke occasionally, though I could have participated more. I was usually prepared and engaged in class. **C (Passing)** = I missed about half of the classes. During group discussion, I contributed only occasionally and tended to let others carry the conversation. In class discussions, I rarely spoke and was not always prepared and engaged in class. **D (Needs Improvement)** = I missed many classes (more than half). During group discussions, I rarely or never contributed. Admittedly, I was often unprepared or disengaged. **F (Failing)** = I missed most classes and made little or no effort to participate in discussions. *Please note that missing classes due to a religious observance, specific AEC accommodation, military deployment, or a University-sponsored event do not count toward absences when you estimate how many classes you missed.* Since you are personally keeping track of and self-reporting your participation, I do not expect you to e-mail me when you miss class unless you need something from me!

LATE ASSIGNMENT POLICY

To make it easy to remember, assignments (except your final exam) in this course are always due **Sundays at 11:59pm**. In the case that you fall ill or otherwise cannot complete your work on time, I have built flexibility into the course in the following ways:

- All students have one free, no-questions-asked extension to turn in an assignment late **for any reason**, no questions asked. If you wish to use your extension, *comment on the assignment "I am using my one free extension"* when you submit it to Canvas. No need to e-mail me that you're using your extension unless you can't figure out how to comment on the assignment. Note that an extension on the final exam (beyond 24 hours) may not be possible with the tight grading deadline. Please reach out as soon as possible if you feel that you'll need an extension on that assignment.
- Without the late pass, if an assignment is turned in **more than 24 hours** after the due date, the assignment will be marked off 5% (max score is now 95%). If 48 hours have passed, the assignment will be marked off 10% (max score is now 90%). Anything after 72 hours will receive the max late penalty of 15% off (max score is now 85%). If you fall behind more than 72 hours, I recommend skipping the assignment and completing it later instead of continuing to fall behind! All late work must be turned in by the last day of Week 10 of classes (**Friday December 5th at 5pm**) to ensure that all assignments can be graded before the grading deadline. Canvas will lock you out of submitting assignments at that time.

ACCESS & ACCOMMODATIONS

The University of Oregon and I are dedicated to fostering inclusive, equitable, and accessible learning environments for all students. The [Accessible Education Center](#) (AEC) assists students with disabilities in reducing barriers in the educational experience. You may be eligible for accommodations for a variety of disabilities – apparent disabilities, such as a mobility or physical disability, or non-apparent disabilities, such as chronic illnesses or psychological disabilities. If you have or think you have a disability and experience academic barriers, please contact the Accessible Education Center (Location: 360 Oregon Hall; 541-346-1155; uoaec@uoregon.edu) to discuss appropriate accommodations or support. The details of your disability will be kept confidential with the AEC and you are not expected to share this information with others. However, I invite you to discuss any approved accommodations or access needs at any time with me.

ACCOMMODATIONS FOR RELIGIOUS OBSERVANCES

The University of Oregon respects the right of all students to observe their religious holidays, and will make reasonable accommodations, upon request, for these observances. If you need an extension on an assignment this term because of a religious obligation or observance, please fill out the [Student Religious Accommodation Request form](#) and send it to me within the first weeks of the course so we can make arrangements in advance.

INTERESTED IN GRADUATE SCHOOL IN SOCIAL PSYCHOLOGY?

Please don't hesitate to come to office hours if you'd like to talk to me about graduate school in psychology. I am a recent (Summer 2024) graduate of UO's PhD program in Social Psychology and am always happy to share my experience. I can't speak too much to graduate school in mental health fields (more so to research psychology), but I can direct you to people who can!

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE USE

You are permitted (and encouraged) to use AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Grammarly) to assist with brainstorming ideas or refining your writing. However, keep in mind that AI can and often does provide inaccurate or overly simplistic responses, and you are responsible for the accuracy and quality of the work that you submit. If you choose to use these tools, then **they must not prevent you from achieving the learning goals of the course**. Relying on AI to think for you – such as copying a response directly from ChatGPT and submitting it as your own -- will hinder your learning and therefore is considered a violation of the academic integrity policy for this course.

ACADEMIC DISHONESTY

Any form of academic dishonesty, including getting outside help on quizzes, plagiarizing of any kind, improper use of AI (as outlined in the policy above), or lying to the instructor or a GTF will not be tolerated in this class. Please complete any assignments labeled “quiz” completely on your own, without the use of AI, the internet, or other students. If you have questions about what is considered academic dishonesty for this course, or if you are struggling with your coursework to the point that you feel you have no choice but to violate our academic integrity policy, please reach out to the instructor, the AEC, and/ or the dean of students. If I detect any academic dishonesty, I will follow the procedure to handle misconduct as outlined by the University, meaning that instances of suspected cheating or plagiarizing will be reported to the University.

CLASSROOM CLIMATE

While studying moral psychology, we are bound to hear from others who do not agree with our moral values, which will cause us to feel deeply uncomfortable. There’s nothing we hold more sacred than our moral beliefs. I do not expect to agree with you on everything, and I do not expect you to agree with your classmates on everything. We are a group with diverse backgrounds and experiences. You will never be graded on your moral views and opinions, only the rigor of psychological evidence you provide to support your claims and arguments. In discussion, we must make it a priority that each person in this class has the opportunity to speak and challenge each other’s ideas.

For discussions, we will follow the guidelines outlined below (which I am happy to add to). Continued enrollment in the course indicates agreement that you will abide by these guidelines.

- (1) Treat others with respect, even when you disagree with them about their ideas or beliefs. For instance, instead of attacking the speaker (e.g., “you are wrong and dumb for thinking that”), focus on disagreeing with the claim or idea by providing contradictory research findings or personal experiences.
- (2) Listening is just as important as sharing your ideas. Make sure to allow others the chance to contribute to the conversation. If you have been speaking too much (or too little), make sure to adjust accordingly so that we hear from a lot of different perspectives.
- (3) Allow others (and yourself) to make mistakes and learn from them. We don’t always say what we mean, and there are things we don’t know yet. Open yourself up to learning new things about yourself and give others the space to do the same.

If you do not feel comfortable participating in a class discussion or believe there is more that I could be doing to promote a more effective learning environment, I urge you to come talk to me. I will always listen to your concerns with respect and an open mind and will make adjustments when appropriate.

YOUR WELLBEING

During your college experience, you may feel overwhelmed or stressed, experience anxiety or depression, struggle with relationships, or just need help navigating challenges in your life. If you're facing such challenges, you don't need to handle them on your own--there's help and support on campus. Getting help is a courageous thing to do—for yourself and those you care about. [University Health Services](#) helps students cope with difficult emotions and life stressors. If you need general resources on coping with stress or want to talk with another student who has been in the same place as you, visit the Duck Nest (located in the EMU on the ground floor) and get help from one of the specially trained Peer Wellness Advocates. University Counseling Services (UCS) has a team of dedicated staff members to support you with your concerns, many of whom can provide identity-based support. All clinical services are free and confidential. Find out more at counseling.uoregon.edu or by calling 541-346-3227 (anytime UCS is closed, the After-Hours Support and Crisis Line is available by calling this same number).

BASIC NEEDS

Being able to meet your basic needs is foundational to your success as a student. If you are having difficulty affording food, don't have a stable, safe place to live, or are struggling to meet another need, visit the [UO Basic Needs Resource](#) page for information on how to get support. They have information food, housing, healthcare, childcare, transportation, technology, finances (including emergency funds), and legal support. If your need is urgent, please contact the Care and Advocacy Program by calling 541-346-3216, filling out the [Community Care and Support form](#), or by [scheduling an appointment](#) with an advocate.

ACADEMIC DISRUPTION DUE TO CAMPUS EMERGENCY

In the event of a campus emergency that disrupts academic activities, course requirements, deadlines, and grading percentages are subject to change. Information about changes in this course will be communicated as soon as possible by email, and on Canvas. If we are not able to meet face-to-face, students should immediately log onto Canvas and read any announcements and/or access alternative assignments. Students are also expected to continue coursework as outlined in this syllabus or other instructions on Canvas.

ACADEMIC DISRUPTION DUE TO CAMPUS EMERGENCY

It is generally expected that class will meet unless the University is officially closed for inclement weather. If it becomes necessary to cancel class while the University remains open, this will be announced on Canvas and by email. Updates on inclement weather and closure are also communicated as described on the [Inclement Weather](#) webpage.

REPORTING OBLIGATIONS

I am a designated reporter. For information about my reporting obligations as an employee, please see [Employee Reporting Obligations](#) on the Office of Investigations and Civil Rights Compliance (OICRC) website. Students experiencing sex- or gender-based discrimination, harassment or violence should call the 24-7 hotline 541-346-SAFE [7244] or visit safe.uoregon.edu for help. Students experiencing all forms of prohibited discrimination or harassment may contact the Dean of Students Office at 541-346-3216 or the non-confidential Title IX Coordinator/OICRC at 541-346-3123 to request information and resources. Students are not required to participate in an investigation to receive support, including requesting academic supportive measures. Additional resources are available at investigations.uoregon.edu/how-get-support. I am also a mandatory reporter of child abuse. Please find more information at [Mandatory Reporting of Child Abuse and Neglect](#).

FALL 2025 COURSE SCHEDULE

WEEK	DATE	TOPIC, ASSIGNMENTS, & READINGS
Week 1 – The Moral Domain	Tues 9/30	Lecture topic: Course overview: What is moral psychology? Required readings: Course Syllabus
	Thurs 10/2	Mini lecture & discussion topic: Moralization: How does a belief become a <i>moral</i> belief? Required readings: - Skitka, L. J., Washburn, A. N., & Carsel, T. S. (2015). The psychological foundations and consequences of moral conviction. <i>Current Opinion in Psychology</i>, 6, 41-44. - Tetlock, P. E. (2003). Thinking the unthinkable: Sacred values and taboo cognitions. <i>Trends in cognitive sciences</i>, 7(7), 320-324.
	Sun 10/5	Reflection 1 Due @ 11:59PM
	Tues 10/7	Lecture topic: Trolley problems and other sacrificial dilemmas (or: when is it wrong to sacrifice one person to save five?) Required readings: Greene, J. D., Cushman, F. A., Stewart, L. E., Lowenberg, K., Nystrom, L. E., & Cohen, J. D. (2009). Pushing moral buttons: The interaction between personal force and intention in moral judgment. <i>Cognition</i>, 111(3), 364-371.
Week 2 – Moral Dilemmas	Thurs 10/9	Mini lecture & discussion topic: Prosocial lying: When is it okay to lie? Required readings: - Stroud (2022). Ethical dilemma: Would you lie? [Video]. - Levine, E. E., & Lupoli, M. J. (2022). Prosocial lies: Causes and consequences. <i>Current Opinion in Psychology</i>, 43, 335-340.
	Sun 10/12	Quiz 1 Due @ 11:59PM
	Tues 10/14	Lecture topic: Social intuitionism and harmless wrongs (or: is it wrong to eat your dog?) Required readings: Haidt, J. (2001). The emotional dog and its rational tail: a social intuitionist approach to moral judgment. <i>Psychological review</i>, 108(4), 814.
Week 3 – Moral Judgment	Thurs 10/16	Mini lecture & discussion topic: Why do people disagree about what is “morally wrong”? Required readings: Schein, C., & Gray, K. (2018). The theory of dyadic morality: Reinventing moral judgment by redefining harm. <i>Personality and Social Psychology Review</i>, 22(1), 32-70.
	Sun 10/19	Reflection 2 Due @ 11:59PM

Week 4 – Social Judgment I	Tues 10/21	Lecture topic: Moral impression formation: Evaluating whether an apple is good or bad Required readings: - Hartman, R., Blakey, W., & Gray, K. (2022). Deconstructing moral character judgments. <i>Current Opinion in Psychology</i>, 43, 205-212. - Yip, J. A., & Schweitzer, M. E. (2015). Trust promotes unethical behavior: Excessive trust, opportunistic exploitation, and strategic exploitation. <i>Current Opinion in Psychology</i>, 6, 216-220.
	Thurs 10/23	Mini lecture & discussion topic: Virtue Signaling: Does telling people about your good deeds make you appear <i>less</i> moral? Required readings: Berman, J. Z., & Silver, I. (2022). Prosocial behavior and reputation: When does doing good lead to looking good? <i>Current opinion in psychology</i>, 43, 102-107.
	Sun 10/26	Quiz 2 Due @ 11:59PM
Week 5 – Social Judgment II	Tues 10/28	Lecture: When do we excuse someone who does bad things from blame and moral responsibility? Required readings: Alicke, M., Rogers, R., & Taylor, S. (2018). What is blame and why do we love it? In K. Gray & J. Graham (Eds.) <i>Atlas of moral psychology</i>, 382-390.
	Thurs 10/30	Mini lecture & discussion topic: How, when, and why should we punish for moral transgressions? Required readings: Tullett, A. M. (2022). The Limitations of Social Science as the Arbiter of Blame: An Argument for Abandoning Retribution. <i>Perspectives on Psychological Science</i>.
	Sun 11/2	Case Study Exam 1 Due @ 11:59PM
Week 6 – Understanding moral behavior	Tues 11/4	Lecture topic: Egoistic motives for altruism: What do we gain from doing good? Required readings: Dunn, E. W., Aknin, L. B., & Norton, M. I. (2014). Prosocial spending and happiness: Using money to benefit others pays off. <i>Current directions in psychological science</i>, 23(1), 41-47.
	Thurs 11/6	Mini lecture & discussion topic: Empathy and its limits: Would abandoning empathy lead to a <i>more</i> moral society? Required readings: - TVO Today (2017). Paul Bloom: Against Empathy. [Video] - Zaki, J. (2018). Empathy is a moral force. In K. Gray & J. Graham (Eds.), <i>Atlas of Moral Psychology</i> (pp. 49–58). Guilford Press.
	Sun 11/9	Quiz 3 Due @ 11:59PM

Tues 11/11 No Class (Veteran's Day)

**Week 7 –
Understanding
immoral
behavior (bad
barrels)**

**Thurs
11/13**

Lecture topic: Bad barrels: Anonymity, unidentified victims, peer influence, and prosocial motives

Required readings:

- Zimbardo, P. (2008). The psychology of evil [[Video](#)].
- Sanderson, C. A. (2020). The myth of monsters. In *The bystander effect: The psychology of courage and inaction* (pp. 3-24). Harvard University Press.

Sun 11/16

Reflection 3 Due @ 11:59PM

**Week 8 – The
Moral Self**

Tues 11/18

Lecture topic: Maintaining a positive moral self-concept when we do bad things

Required readings:

- Dunning, D. (2016). False moral superiority. In A. G. Miller (Ed.), *The social psychology of good and evil* (pp. 249 – 269). The Guilford Press.
- Shalvi, S., Gino, F., Barkan, R., & Ayal, S. (2015). Self-serving justifications: Doing wrong and feeling moral. *Current Directions in Psychological Science*, 24(2), 125-130.

**Thurs
11/20**

Mini lecture & discussion topic: Moral accounting: Do good behaviors license us to misbehave?

Required readings:

- Merritt, A. C., Effron, D. A., & Monin, B. (2010). Moral self-licensing: When being good frees us to be bad. *Social and personality psychology compass*, 4(5), 344-357.

Sun 11/23

Quiz 4 Due @ 11:59PM

**Week 9 –
Understanding
immoral
behavior (bad
apples)**

Tues 11/25

Lecture topic: Bad apples: psychopaths, Machiavellians, narcissists, sadists, and perpetual victims

Required readings:

- Kiehl, K. A. (2014). The assassins. In *The psychopath whisperer: The science of those without conscience* (pp. 50 - 77). Crown Publishing.
- Campbell, K. (2016). The psychology of narcissism [[Video](#)].

**Thurs
11/27**

No Class (Thanksgiving Holiday)

Sun 11/30

Reflection 4 Due @ 11:59PM

Week 10 – Moral Understanding	Tues 12/2	Lecture topic: Two Americas? Liberal versus conservative morality Required readings: Haidt, J. (2012). The moral foundations of politics. In <i>The righteous mind: Why good people are divided by politics and religion</i> (pp. 150-179). Pantheon Books.
	Thurs 12/4	Mini-lecture & discussion topic: Can and should we try to change people's moral beliefs? Does viewpoint diversity have value, or does it only create conflict? Required readings: Gray, K. J. (2025). Understanding: Telling stories of harm. In <i>Outraged: Why we fight about morality and politics and how to find common ground</i> (Ch. 10). Pantheon Books.
	Sun 12/7	Quiz 5 Due @ 11:59PM (Optional!! Canvas drops lowest quiz grade)

Finals week

Case Study Exam 2 Due Wednesday December 10th at 11:59PM